

DROPPED DAYS

- **On October 16, the interim government of Bangladesh cancelled eight national holidays started by the Sheikh Hasina regime**
- **The days include those commemorating Mujib's call for independence on Mar. 7, 1971, his birth and death annivesaries (Mar. 17, Aug. 15)**
- **Birth anniversaries of his wife and two sons (Aug. 8 and 5, Oct. 18), Constitution Day (Nov. 4) and Smart Bangladesh Day (Dec. 12) are scrapped too**

ber 12 was also cancelled.

The advisor to the ministry of posts, telecommunications and information technology, Nahid Islam, told journalists that his government doesn't recognise Bangabandhu as the 'father of the nation'. The 26-year-old stressed that Mujib has been made "controversial" by the Awami League. "We have had anti-British struggles, 1947, 1971, 1990 and now 2024. We have many founding fathers; our freedom came through their collective struggles," he said. Reacting to these moves, the Awami League stated on X: "Dr Yunus's reset button theory is an assault on Bangladesh's founding ideals." Other parties, including leftist ones, criticised the move too.

With the exit of Hasina, there have been open critiques of Mujib—his creation of the political front Bangladesh Krishak Sramik Awami League (BaKSAL) in February 1975, outlawing all other parties, and his alleged failure to control the 1974 famine are under public scrutiny. The Awami League regime has been accused of brushing these episodes under the carpet and projecting Mujib as an untainted hero. It also allegedly denied the legacy and importance of leaders such as A.K. Fazlul Haque, H.S. Suhrawardy, Maulana Bhasani and Ziaul Haque Zia.

THE INTERIM GOVERNMENT IS TRYING TO WIPE OUT THE MEMORY AND LEGACY OF SHEIKH MUJIBUR RAHMAN

"Independent Bangladesh has a legacy of contiguous struggle.... This reality was mocked in the last one and a half decades, as a fascist government forced our people to worship Sheikh Mujib as an individual. The sacrifices of all other leaders were ignored, just like electoral and human rights," says Md. Adnan Arif Salim, assistant professor of history at the Bangladesh Open University, voicing this line.

Under Hasina's stringent Digital Security Act, 2018, criticism of the 1971 liberation war or Mujib would attract imprisonment and/or fine. But experts claim that the ambiguity of the law allowed the regime to silence all dissent. According to a report by the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, over 1,500 cases were registered under the DSA between 2018 and 2021.

Didarul Bhuiyan, a member of the think tank Rashtrachinta, was arrested under the DSA in May 2020 after it published a report on the glaring disparity in relief distribution by the government during the Covid pandemic: he was in custody until September, till a high court granted him bail. He has met representatives of the interim government with multiple reform proposals, including a demand to scrap the Cyber Security Act (the revised version of DSA) and a restructure of the process of parliamentary legislation."I have spoken to many of the advisors, including Nahid Islam. But I haven't heard back from them," Bhuiyan tells INDIA TODAY. "I believe it is more important to scrap these savage legislations and pay attention to other issues than to cancel national days."

In India, the decision to scrap the national days and a statement stripping Bangabandhu of his status as 'father of the nation' have been criticised, though there has been no official statement. According to former army chief Gen. Shankar Roy Chowdhury, a veteran of 1971, any decision to undermine Mujib is equivalent to belittling the Indian contribution to the liberation war. "The situation is such that we need to question the ends of the war. Was it fought for Bengalis? Or Bengali Muslims? Or Bengali Hindus? Bangladesh is moving towards total Islamisation," he says.

On October 17, hours after the International Crimes Tribunal in Bangladesh issued an arrest warrant for Hasina, citing her alleged involvement in mass killings during the August protests, India confirmed that she was still in the country. Asif Nazrul, law advisor to the interim government, cited provisions of the extradition treaty between India and Bangladesh and claimed that India is bound to follow it. Amidst such a tense situation, India is unlikely to comment on the neighbouring nation's decision to re-evaluate its history. ■